

600–1100

THE AGE OF MIGRATIONS

After the western Roman Empire collapsed, people started migrating to new areas, sometimes by invasion and conquest, sometimes through peaceable settlement. In Northern European areas, Germanic, Frankish, and Norse-speaking peoples needed warm, water-repelling clothes in the cold climate, so wool was the main cloth used. People in warmer Mediterranean regions had lighter clothing in linens, wools, and sometimes silk – if they could afford it. Both men and women wore loose tunics, based on rectangles sewn together in different styles, and caught with belts. Mantles (cloaks) were draped over tunics, sometimes with status-enhancing fur linings. Men wore trews (the forerunner of trousers) below the waist, wrapped with woollen bands or leather below the knee. Linen shirts were worn as undergarments beneath tunics, and sometimes worn on their own in summer. Surviving clothing from burials reveals a love of finery in embroidery, tablet-woven braids, and intricate jewellery.

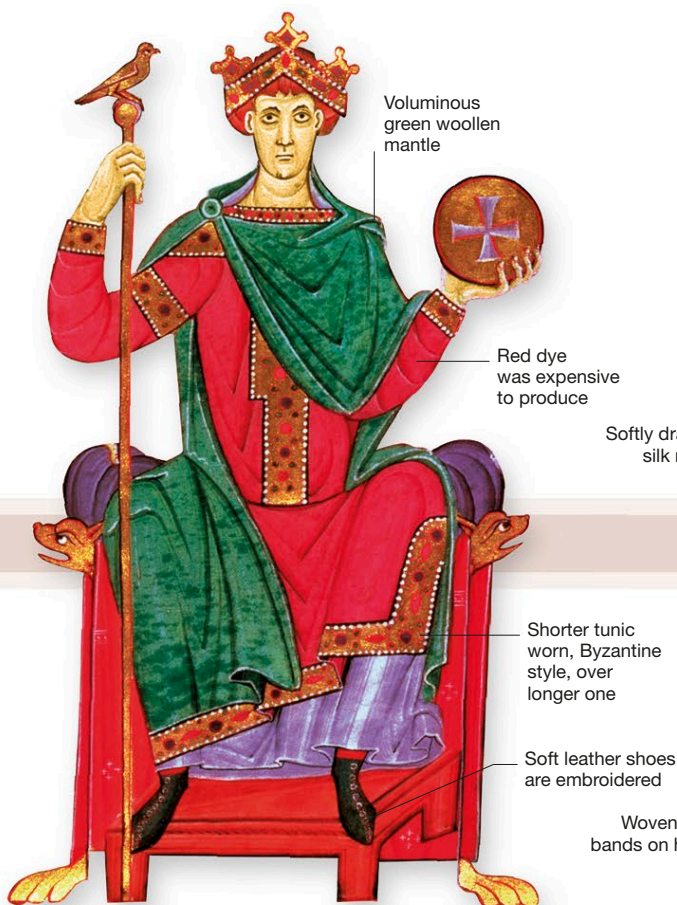
TEXTILE PRODUCTION

Before the horizontal loom's introduction, c.1000, all European weaving was done on vertical looms, held under tension with warp-weights at the bottom. Producing cloth was extremely labour intensive and women carried out most of it at home. Wool, the most common fibre, had to be shorn, cleaned, and carded (brushed), then spun with a drop-spindle. The loom was set up with vertical warp threads, and finally the weft threads were woven horizontally over and under the warp to make cloth. Clothing was based mostly on straight lines, joining the selvages (fabric edges) to minimize waste.



Coptic wool tunic, c.600

Mythological motifs



Imperial majesty This illumination, c.990, shows the Holy Roman Emperor Otto III in the finest attire possible. His silk tunic is dyed with costly red and embellished with gems and gold. The crown, orb, and sceptre mark his authority.

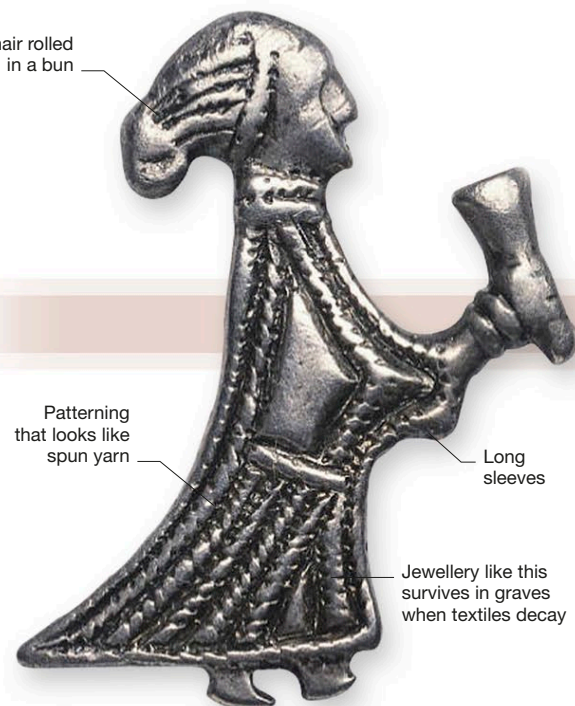
Voluminous green woollen mantle

Red dye was expensive to produce

Shorter tunic worn, Byzantine style, over longer one

Soft leather shoes are embroidered

Woven gold bands on hems



Plaited hair rolled in a bun

Patterning that looks like spun yarn

Long sleeves

Jewellery like this survives in graves when textiles decay

Viking woman Women in some Scandinavian countries wore apron-dresses or apron-skirts. Round or oval brooches were used to hold up the dresses and further decoration came from pendants such as this silver example.



Tunic with matching mantle

Softly draping silk robes

Long undertunic revealed by shorter outer garments

Byzantine silk A 10th-century woman wears sumptuous textiles. Byzantine silk was light and clung to the shape of the body. The undertunic, painted to look blue, was probably made of white linen.